

Nima Thing

Computational social scientist studying political communication, disinformation, and hate speech on social media.

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Profile

- Computational social scientist studying political communication, disinformation, and hate speech on social media, with a focus on Nepal and Europe. My work combines text-as-data methods, large language models, and multimodal analysis with questions about how citizens encounter and respond to political content. Before moving into social science, I worked for six years as a software engineer, which allows me to build and maintain research pipelines independently.

Education

MDS **Hertie School**, Data Science for Public Policy — Berlin, Germany — Aug 2023 – June 2025
- Coursework: Advanced Quantitative Methods, Causal Inference, Machine Learning, Deep Learning, Natural Language Processing, Governance.
- Thesis: TikTok Virality and Political Engagement in Nepal's 2022 Local Elections, supervised by Prof. Dr. Simon Munzert.

PG Dipl. **The Open Institute for Social Science**, Research and Writing in Social Science — Lalitpur, Nepal — Aug 2021 – June 2022
- Coursework: History of Social Thought, Critical Epistemology and Methodology, Contemporary Social Writing, Project Design, Ethnographic Theory, Field Methods, Research Writing.
- Capstone (defense pending): Digital Agriculture in Practice: Institutions, Intermediaries, and Farmer Realities in Nepal.

B.E. **Tribhuvan University**, Electronics and Communication Engineering — Kathmandu, Nepal — 2014 – 2018

Experience

Logiq Media (NGO), Computational Social Science Researcher (part-time) — Berlin — Jan 2026 – present — 10 months
Volunteer researcher (Jan–Mar 2026); part-time from Apr 2026.
- EU-funded SHIFT project on disinformation narratives in 13 European countries: reviewed the cross-national survey questionnaire, contributed to audience segment profiles, and analyzed narrative coding.
- Co-lead the design of creator-led interventions to reach politically disengaged audiences, including hypotheses, audience selection, and evaluation against creators' engagement baselines.
- Lead developer of Elfbot, a human-supervised comment moderation tool for politicians facing online abuse. It classifies comments with structured LLM prompting and includes an LLM-based fact-checking workflow that retrieves evidence through web search for human review.

Institute of Communication and Media Studies, University of Bern, Research Assistant — Remote — Aug 2026 – Aug 2026 — 1 month
- Built an LLM-based pipeline to classify antisemitic content (IHRA definition) in about 30,000 chatbot responses, comparing six LLMs (F1 = 0.86).
- With Dr. Mykola Makhortykh, tested LLM safety filters against prompting strategies such as role-play framing (presented at the Weizenbaum Institute).

Policy Entrepreneurs, Inc. (PEI), Technical Consultant, Gen Z Digital Movement Study — Remote
- Network analysis of about 5,000 Nepali Reddit authors before the Sep 2025 Gen Z protest. — May 2026 – June 2026, 2 months

Weizenbaum Institute, Platform Algorithms and Digital Propaganda, Short-term Expert (Research Infrastructure) — Berlin, Dec 2025 – Dec 2025, 1 month
- Built a longitudinal data-collection tool to study incidental exposure to Kremlin disinformation via search engines and LLMs, with Dr. Elizaveta Kuznetsova and Dr. Mykola Makhortykh. (GitHub, access on request).

DeepTrace: South Asia Deepfake Detection, Research Assistant (Volunteer) — Remote, Nov 2025 – Jan 2026, 3 months
- Under the supervision of Dr. Dilrukshi Gamage, developed an annotation codebook and benchmark for AI-generated visual content in South Asian contexts.

Koç University, Human-AI Interaction Lab, Graduate Research Intern (Volunteer) — Istanbul, Turkey, July 2025 – Sept 2025, 3 months
- With Prof. Merih Angin, worked on a full-stack restaurant application: server-side database optimizations, dynamic UI rendering, agent-specific text-to-speech (TTS) integration, and named-entity recognition features for restaurant search.
- Improved backend data access for the customer and management portals, reducing redundant Firebase calls.
- For the Politus project (now Enlighten AI), built TikTok data-collection tooling and compared third-party social media data providers.

Welthungerhilfe, Working Student, Data Engineering — Bonn, Germany, Apr 2024 – July 2025, 1 year 4 months
- Built automated data pipelines (Python, PySpark, Microsoft Fabric, Azure Data Factory) integrating staff and training data from external APIs.
- Designed robust API integrations (token management, pagination, error handling, rate limiting) and improved pipeline logging and monitoring.
- Built Excel tools for semi-automated analysis of internal surveys.
- Ran proofs of concept for metadata capture and data lineage (PyApacheAtlas, Microsoft Purview); technical contact for teams and helped onboard junior staff.

Immobilien Scout GmbH, Quality Specialist (Mobile) — Berlin, Germany, Oct 2023 – Apr 2024, 7 months
- Ran integration and A/B tests for the Android and iOS apps, and introduced the Maestro framework for automated mobile testing.

Qniverse Pvt. Ltd., Lead Automation Engineer — Kathmandu, Nepal, Aug 2022 – Sept 2023, 1 year 2 months
- Led test automation and mentored the QA team on international research projects, including several UKRI-funded projects.
- Built browser automation and web-scraping tools (Selenium, Playwright) reused across projects.
- Received the Employment Guru Award (2023) for QA leadership.

Verisk Nepal Pvt. Ltd., Software Engineer, Data Analytics — Lalitpur, Nepal, Feb 2019 – Aug 2022, 3 years 7 months
- Built performance-testing and schema-comparison tools (.NET Core/C#) for REST APIs, which cut deployment checks from hours to minutes.
- Wrote Python regression test suites for an AWS/Snowflake data-ingestion pipeline.
- Received the Verisk "Way to Go" recognition (2020).

Working Papers and Proceedings

- Thing, N. (2026). Beyond the ban: Co-engagement network signals on Nepali Reddit before the Sep 8 Gen Z protest. In *How are you, democracy? Proceedings of the SOSEC Academic Conference* (pp. 40–44). SOSEC & FZI. Extended abstract. Link
- Thing, N., & Logiq Media (2026). Fact-checking in the feed: The gap between output metrics and public reception. Working paper. Draft

Projects

TikTok Virality and Political Engagement in Nepal's 2022 Local Elections 2024 – 2026
MSc thesis, Hertie School (revised 2026). Code · Poster

- Built a multimodal pipeline (Whisper, GPT-4o image captions and translations, multilingual embeddings) for 2,964 election videos sampled from 28,165.
- Political attention concentrated among accounts with large audiences, and content about independent candidates drew more attention than general election content. Communication styles were hand-coded with a codebook developed for the study.

Reading the Crowd: Perceived Social Consensus and Credibility of Polarized News 2026
Research proposal for a survey experiment on how source identity and consensus cues shape the credibility of polarized news among young Nepali Facebook users.

Online Toxicity and Community Structure on Bluesky 2025
SICSS-Saarbrücken group project; I led stance classification and network analysis of 156,000 posts.

Bias in Toxic Language Detection 2024 – 2025
Group project, Deep Learning course, Hertie School; I led fine-tuning and bias evaluation across gender, religion, and race groups.

Conference Presentations

- *Youth in a Digital Society*, University of Potsdam (poster, thesis), 2026 — Poster
- Turkish Computational Social Science Conference (TCSS), Koç University (talk, thesis), 2026 — Slides
- *How Are You, Democracy?* SOSEC Academic Conference, FZI Karlsruhe (poster, Reddit study), 2026 — Poster
- Global South AI Workshop, IJCAI-ECAI (poster, toxicity bias), 2026
- SSaLM Workshop, Weizenbaum Institute (poster, toxicity bias), 2025 — Poster
- SICSS-Saarbrücken; MPIB Bounded Rationality Summer School (posters, thesis), 2025 — SICSS poster, MPIB poster

Scholarships, Awards and Summer Schools

- Data for Good Full Scholarship, Dieter Schwarz Stiftung, Hertie School MDS (approx. €36,500), 2023–2025
- Best 3MT Presentation Award, Global South AI Workshop, IJCAI-ECAI, 2026
- SCRIPTS/BGTS Digital Autumn School, Berlin (selected participant), 2026
- Summer Institute in Computational Social Science, SICSS-Saarbrücken (selected participant), 2025
- ESSA Scholarship, BEHAVE Summer School on Agent-Based Modelling for Social Scientists, 2022

Methods and Skills

- **Research methods:** text-as-data, LLM-based annotation and classification, codebook development, survey and experimental design, social network analysis, regression and causal inference (coursework)
- **LLMs & NLP:** prompt-based classification, LLM evaluation, retrieval-augmented workflows, multilingual embeddings, transformer fine-tuning, Whisper
- **Programming:** Python, R, SQL, Git; web data collection for research
- **Languages:** Nepali (native), English (fluent), Hindi (professional), German (A2, learning toward B1)
- **Certificates:** Digital Governance (2025), Algorithmic Fairness (2025)